

Forecasting MTSS in Grand Rapids Public Schools



July 2025



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Existing Strengths & Opportunities in MTSS



Clarifying and communicating the goals of MTSS to stakeholders can further align our collective efforts with the district's strategic vision. Although school leaders and teams may be knowledgeable about the impacts of an effectively installed MTSS, there have not been explicit connections made to the MICIP or Scholar Priority Outcomes.

While components of MTSS exist, there is an opportunity to build stronger alignment across systems and practices. This includes district system and processes, language and definitions around tiers of support, Synergy data reporting, and the work of school-based intervention teams.

A District Implementation Team has been guiding MTSS work for several years. This team is a cross-cutting work group of district leadership who have been designing and implementing the MTSS for Grand Rapids Public Schools.

A cohort of schools has completed one stage of MTSS Installation professional learning. This cohort is comprised of 8 schools: Alger Middle School, Buchannan Elementary School, Campus Elementary School, Innovation Central Middle School, Ottawa Hills High School, Riverside Middle School, Union High School, and Westwood Middle School.

Professional learning was focused on Tier 1 behavior interventions. This learning was made up of 3 3-hour trainings and supported by a monthly Community of Practice hosted by the Department of Social & Emotional Learning.

Opportunities to strengthen installation. Despite starting the first cohort of schools in MTSS installation, schools have not been provided with a scope and sequence as to the professional learning that will take place. There also has not been an agreement around additional cohorts and the training and installation pathway they will follow.

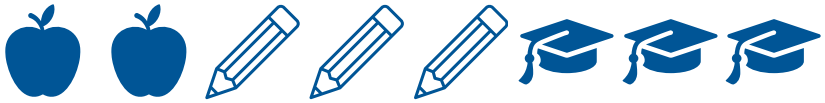
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Unpacking Cohort 1

Who Participated?



7 Neighborhood Schools
1 Theme School



2 Elementary Schools
3 Comprehensive Middle Schools
3 High Schools

Professional Learning



9 Hours of Professional Learning

Session 1: Guiding principles, Team structure, identifying desired behaviors

Session 2: Data sources, defining and teaching behavior expectations

Session 3: Acknowledgement, consistent responses, action planning

Strengthening Implementation



Future professional learning can be designed in ways that better reflect the diverse scheduling needs and strengths of school teams.



Providing clearer connections between professional learning, school initiatives, and the Strategic Plan will further support meaningful implementation.



Some systems barriers - such as the use of the Synergy Minor Behavior tab, arose during Professional Learning.

Impact Data

School teams completed a Tiered Fidelity Inventory (TFI) to gauge the level of implementation of PBIS Features

On average, Cohort 1 schools had 58% of PBIS Tier 1 features implemented:



3 Cohort 1 schools scored above 70% on the TFI, indicating that PBIS Tier 1 is installed to fidelity



District wide, schools who implemented PBIS Tier 1 to fidelity had:

- Lower suspension Ratio
- Lower rate of Chronic Absenteeism
- Higher average scores on all Panorama domains

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MTSS Vision

In Grand Rapids Public Schools, we envision a Multi-Tiered System of Supports that ensures every scholar receives the academic, behavioral, and social emotional support needed to thrive. Through data-driven practices, tiered supports, and collaborative partnerships, we commit to fostering environments where all students are empowered to achieve their fullest potential and become self-directed, productive members of society.

Alignment to MICIP

MICIP Goal: GRPS will develop and implement and district-wide MTSS framework as measured by the District Capacity Assessment.

A Multi-Tiered System of Supports (MTSS) is a comprehensive framework comprised of a collection of research-based strategies designed to meet the individual needs and assets of the whole child at all achievement levels. MTSS intentionally interconnects the education, health, and human service systems in support of learners, schools, centers, and community outcomes. The five essential components of MTSS are inter-related and complementary. Implementation of the essential components as intended provides educational settings with a framework to organize the strategies and processes needed to support successful learner outcomes. The five essential components include the following: Team-Based Leadership, Tiered Delivery System, Selection and Implementation of Instruction, Interventions and Supports, Comprehensive Screening & Assessment System, Continuous Data-Based Decision Making.

MICIP Goals

Gap Statement: Our current total capacity score is 50% compared to our goal of 80% or higher as measured by the DCA.

Challenge Statement: If we continue to complete the installation items from our installation checklists, then we will improve the overall total DCA score to better support buildings in their implementation of PBIS with fidelity.

Interim Targets: By Fall 2025, we will increase our score on the DCA to 65%.

Alignment to Priority Outcomes

Research supports that the installation of an effective Multi-Tiered System of Supports will lead to the outcomes outlined in the GRPS Strategic Plan Priority Outcomes:



Increase literacy proficiency



Reduce academic disparities for Black and Latino students



Increase student empowerment, belonging, and agency



Increase math proficiency

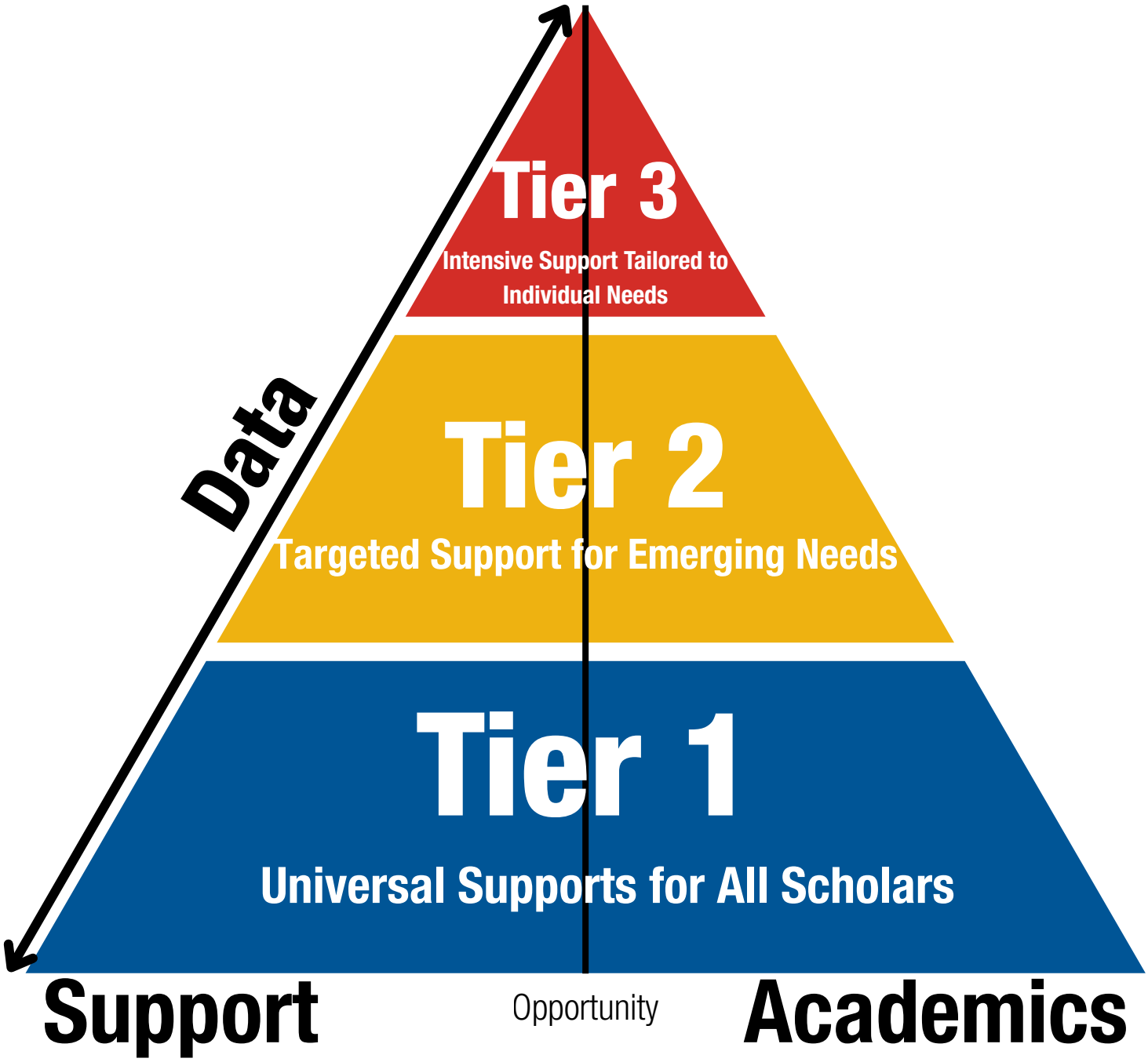


Reduce Black students exclusionary discipline



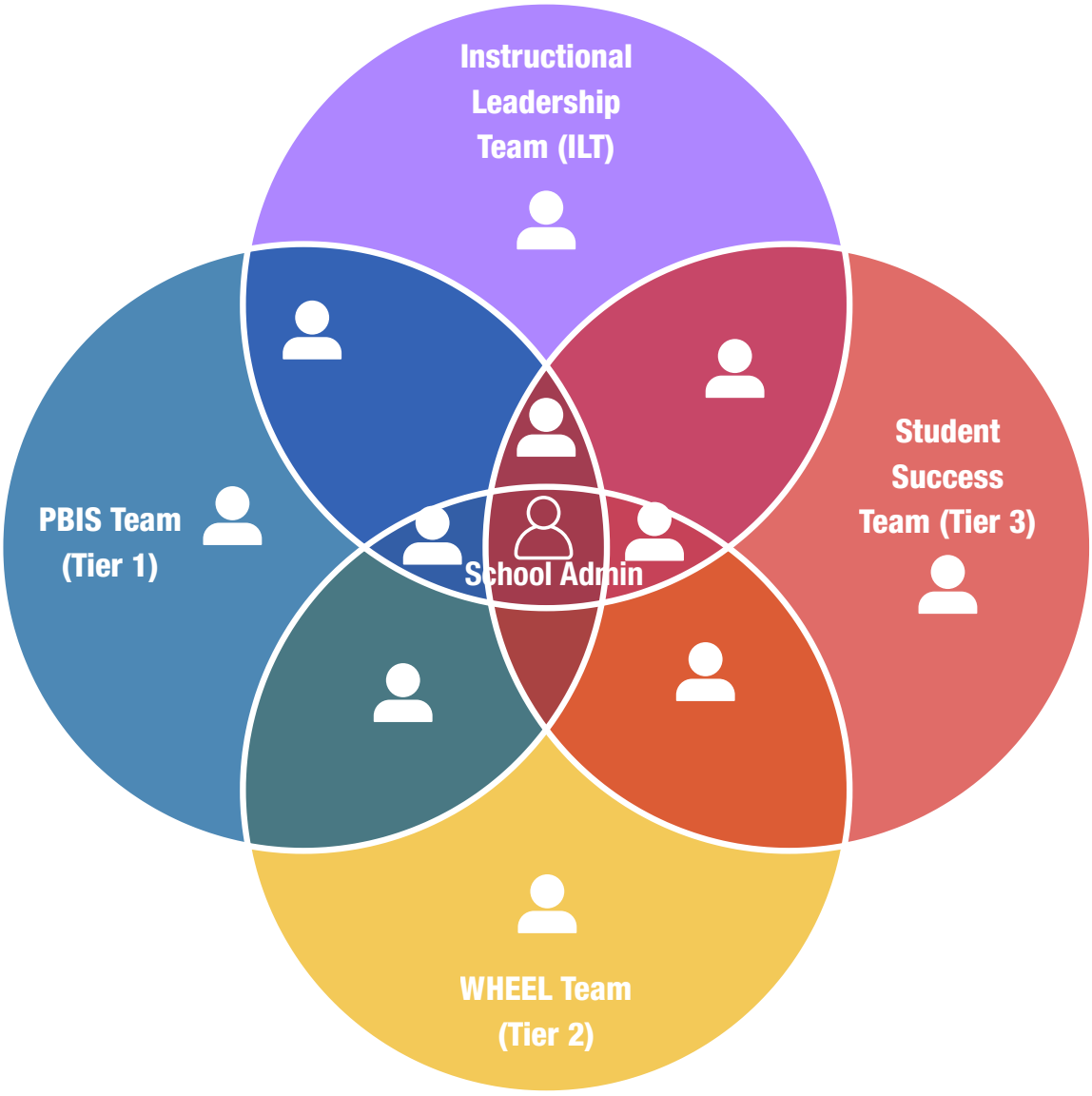
Increase successful transitions from high school to college or career

Redefined MTSS Framework



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Redefined School Leadership Team Structures



Schools might reorganize their school based leadership teams to a more encompassing model. By selecting school staff to a School Leadership Team (SLT), and then delegating subcommittees to guide the instruction & supports of the building, we can ensure that administrators maintain a scaled perspective of the entire MTSS that the school provides.

School-based leadership teams can be customized based on strengths, needs, and staff capacity. This teaming structure is representative of an ideal view of school staffing, capacity and resource disribution. Outlining specifically what teams are responsible for will allow schools the take the work and tailor it to their individual situations.

Responsibilities may vary. Some work - such as Attendance, grade level team meetings, or content area teams, may overlap or require the formation of different teams. Framing this work within the MTSS structure can highlight interconnectedness and increase coherence.

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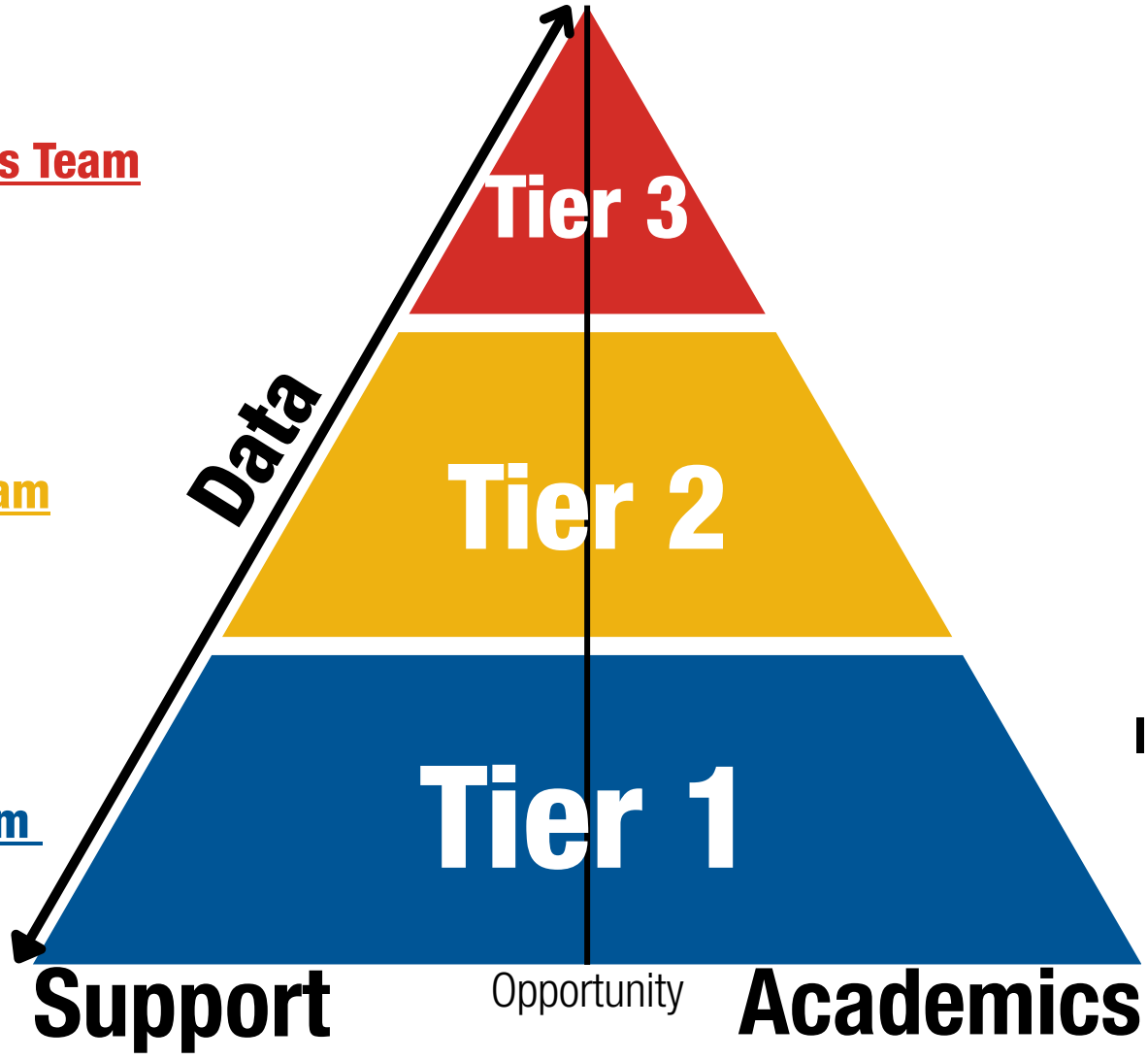
Aligning School Teams to MTSS

Tier 1/2/3 teams serve as "checkpoints" up and down the tiers of available supports based on data.

Student Success Team

Wheel Team

PBIS Team



Instructional Leadership Team

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Aligning Data Sources to MTSS

Data sources are not exclusive to one tier of support, and should build on one another

Data Source	PBIS Team (Tier 1 Behavior)	ILT (Tier 1 Instruction)	WHEEL Team (Tier 2 Behavior)	SST (Tier 3 Behavior)
Electronic Sources	• Minor Behavior Dashboard • Suspension Dashboards • Chronic Absenteeism Dashboards • Building Overview Dashboard	• Mark Distribution Dashboard	• Student profile tab	
Paper Reports	• EWS Report (STU-204) • Daily Attendance Totals (ATD 204, ATD 401) • Period Attendance Totals (ATP 402)	• EWS Report (STU-204)	• Intervention Report (INT-100)	• IEP • 504 Plan
Experience Data	• Tiered Fidelity Inventory • MI Voice reports • Panorama Dashboard	• Instructional Rounds data • Writing & work samples	• Check in/Check Out sheets • Points Sheets • Small Group conversations	• Positive Behavior Support Plan (PBSP) • Functional Behavioral Assessment (FBA)

Readiness

Fidelity of implementation and readiness for MTSS tier installation will be based on the school's completion of the Tiered Fidelity Inventory (TFI).

The Tiered Fidelity inventory is a researched-backed measure of MTSS installation, and has recently been updated to include additional Social & Emotional Learning components, which aligns with priorities outlined in the Grand Rapids Public Schools Michigan Integrated Comprehensive Improvement Plan (MICIP).

Utilizing several measures - including rubrics, interviews, and walkthroughs, along with other coordinated data sources (such as suspensions and minor behaviors), the TFI provides guidance into which schools may be selected for induction into future MTSS Cohorts. A score of 70% or above on the TFI indicates that a tier of support is in place, alongside with regular data reviews - a score below 70% on a particular tier of support would indicate that school would benefit from professional learning around that MTSS component.

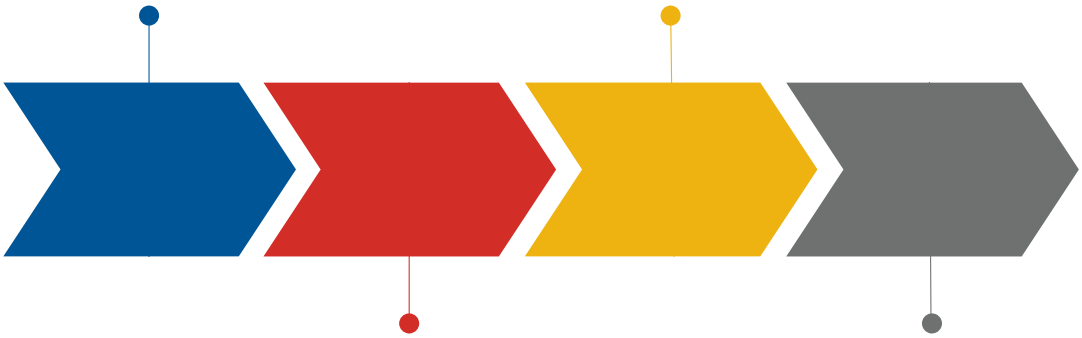
The Department of Social & Emotional Learning conducted Tiered Fidelity Inventory walkthroughs with 32 schools during the 2024-2025 school year, including with all Cohort 1 schools, with a focus on Tier 1 behavior supports. This data can be leveraged to identify schools for Cohort 2, slated to begin professional learning in the 2025-2026 school year.

This process is summarized below:

Fall: Dept. of SEL conducts initial TFI Assessment in all schools.

This TFI measures growth from the previous Spring, as well as providing baseline data for the current school year

Winter/Spring: Cohort schools participate in profressional learning



Fall / Winter: Cohort schools participate in professional learning

Spring: Dept. of SEL conducts growth measure TFI Assessment in all schools.

This TFI measures growth from professional learning, as well as providing data for the year following year

MTSS Installation Scope & Sequence: Cohort Schools



- Team structure and makeup
- Agendas and action items
- Introduce Tiered Fidelity Inventory
- PBIS Expectations
- Reward systems

- PBIS system for classroom management

- Tier 2 behavior systems: Check in/Check out
- Tier 3 behavior systems

- Intensifying behavior interventions

All Cohort schools will participate in regularly calendared data review cycles in the Fall, Winter and Spring after completing Tier 1 behavior professional learning.

How will we know if a school has installed their MTSS, and is ready to move to a state of continuous improvement?

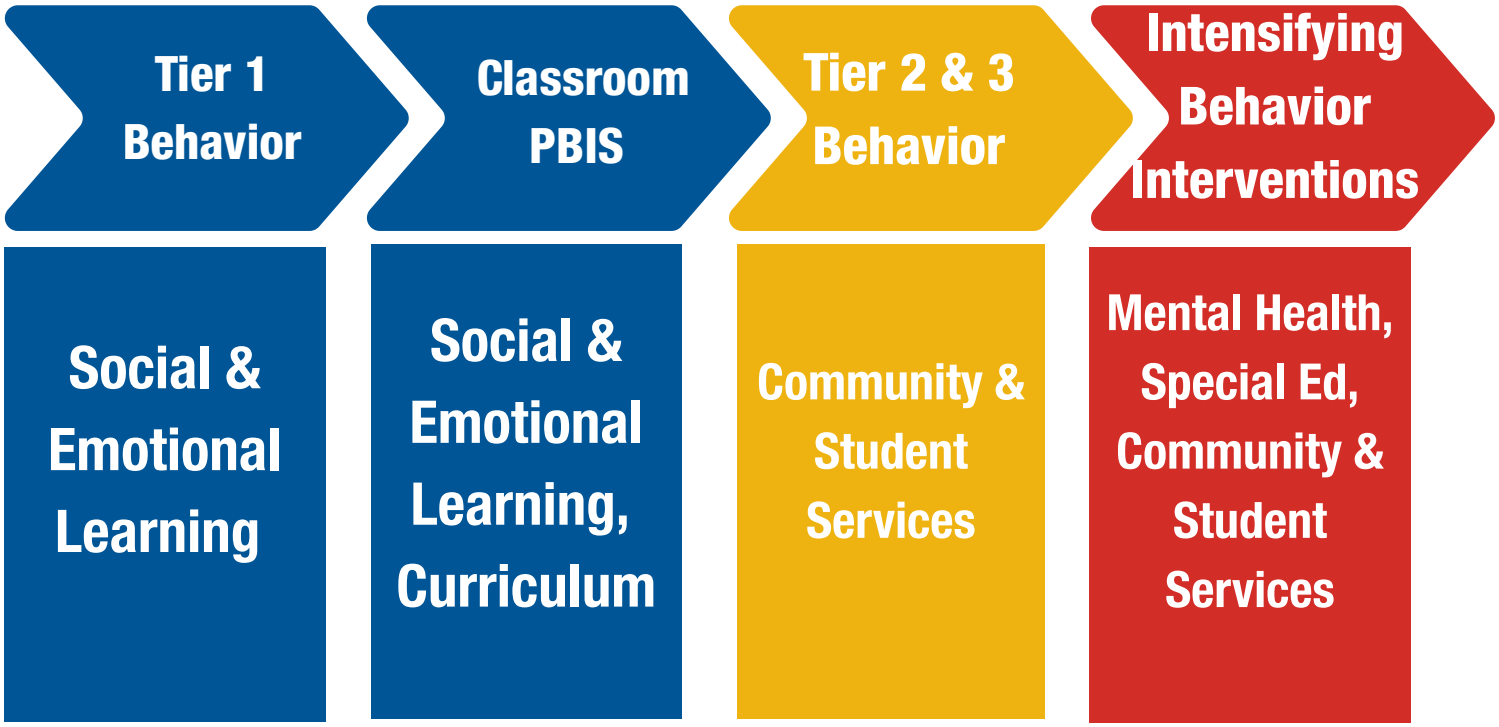
The Tiered Fidelity Inventory will serve as the major indicator of installation progress, and scores of 70% or above in each tier would indicate installation to fidelity. Scores of 70% through every tier would serve as an indicator that MTSS is totally installed in a school.

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MTSS Installation Scope & Sequence: Supporting Departments & Personnel

The designated departments would take on the role of shepherding each cohort of schools through their professional learning and implementation process. This would include:

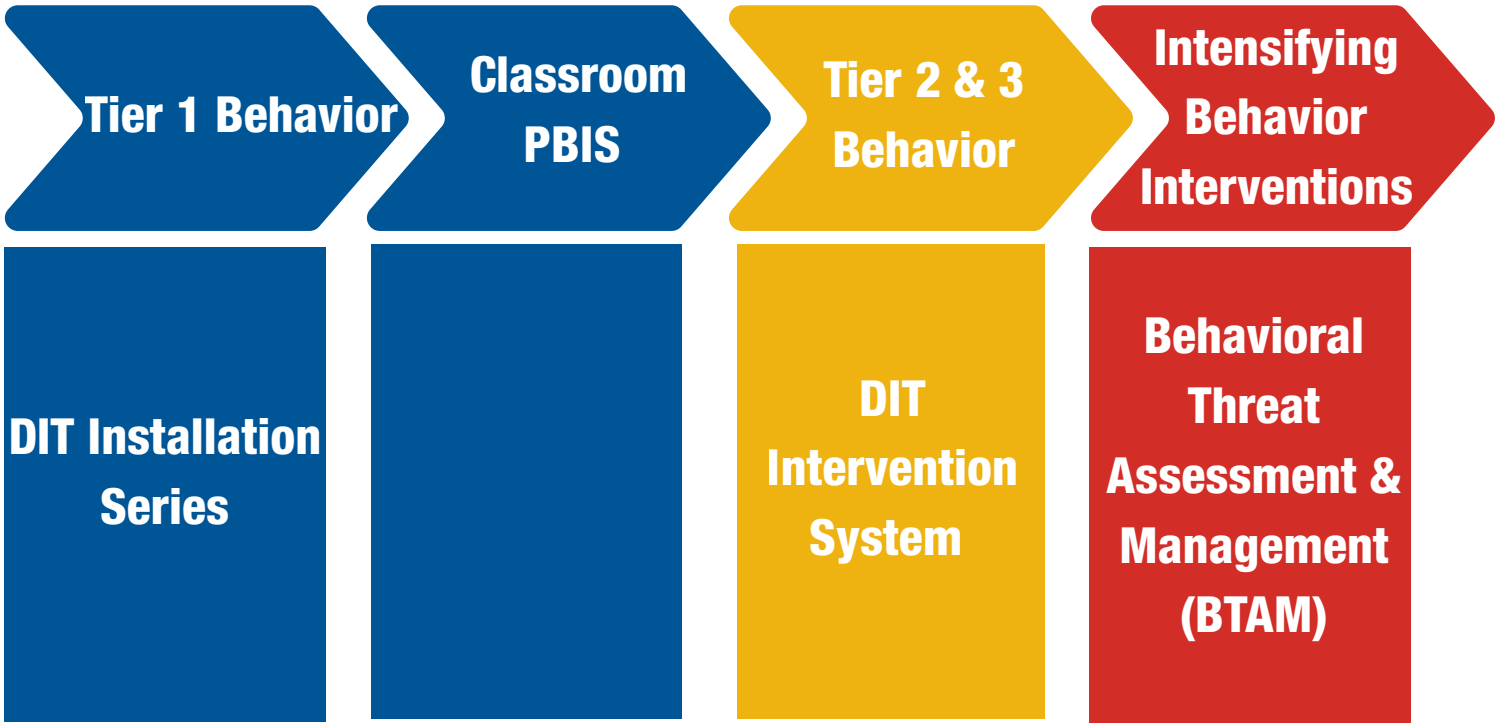
- Attending professional learning with Cohort schools
- Providing documentation around best practices, relevant research, and systems



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MTSS Installation Scope & Sequence: District Implementation Team

The District Implementation Team (DIT) members would attend supporting professional learning to align district systems and structures to tiers of support



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MTSS Installation Scope & Sequence: District

Installing MTSS on the currently prescribed installation scope and sequence, utilizing the cohort model of 8 schools per cohort generates the following timeline:

School Cohorts	2024 - 2025	2025 - 2026	2026 - 2027	2027 - 2028	2028 - 2029	2029 - 2030	2030 - 2031	2031 - 2032
Cohort 1	Tier 1 Behavior	Classroom PBIS	Tier 2 & 3 Behavior Systems	Intensifying Behavior Interventions				
Cohort 2		Tier 1 Behavior	Classroom PBIS	Tier 2 & 3 Behavior Systems	Intensifying Behavior Interventions			
Cohort 3			Tier 1 Behavior	Classroom PBIS	Tier 2 & 3 Behavior Systems	Intensifying Behavior Interventions		
Cohort 4				Tier 1 Behavior	Classroom PBIS	Tier 2 & 3 Behavior Systems	Intensifying Behavior Interventions	
Cohort 5					Tier 1 Behavior	Classroom PBIS	Tier 2 & 3 Behavior Systems	Intensifying Behavior Interventions

Active professional learning & data analysis

Maintenance and continous improvement

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Progress Monitoring & Continuous Improvement

Continuous improvement is a core tenant of an MTSS, and system-wide installation can be divided into several different categories, with measurements available for various stages of the installation process

District Level: Systems, Structures & Processes

Component	Measurement Metric	Frequency of Reporting
Vision, Framework & Goals	Published and shared district wide	Initial install, reviewed annually
Data Reporting Systems (Synergy)	Functional district-wide data system with disaggregated early warning data (attendance, behavior, academics) commonly communicated and utilized district wide	Quarterly data reviews down to school level
Communication Plan	Evidence of communication to stakeholders (District wide, cohort schools)	Quarterly pulse check
Policy & Resource Alignment	Budget, staffing, Scholar Resource guide reflect MTSS as a priority	Quarterly pulse check
Fidelity Measurement Tool	Adoption of Tiered Fidelity Inventory	Initial install
Prioritization of MTSS Installation	District Implementation Team Attendance	Monthly - after DIT meetings

Progress Monitoring & Continuous Improvement, Cont.

Professional Learning & Installation

Component	Measurement Metric	Frequency of Reporting
Professional Learning Scope & Sequence	Installation scope and sequence, calendar of professional learning dates	Annual plan, monitored quarterly
Professional Learning Attendance	Google Form / Attendance sign in	After PL sessions
School Installation	Tiered Fidelity Inventory (up to appropriate tier of Professional Learning)	2x / year (Fall & Spring)

School Level: Impact Data

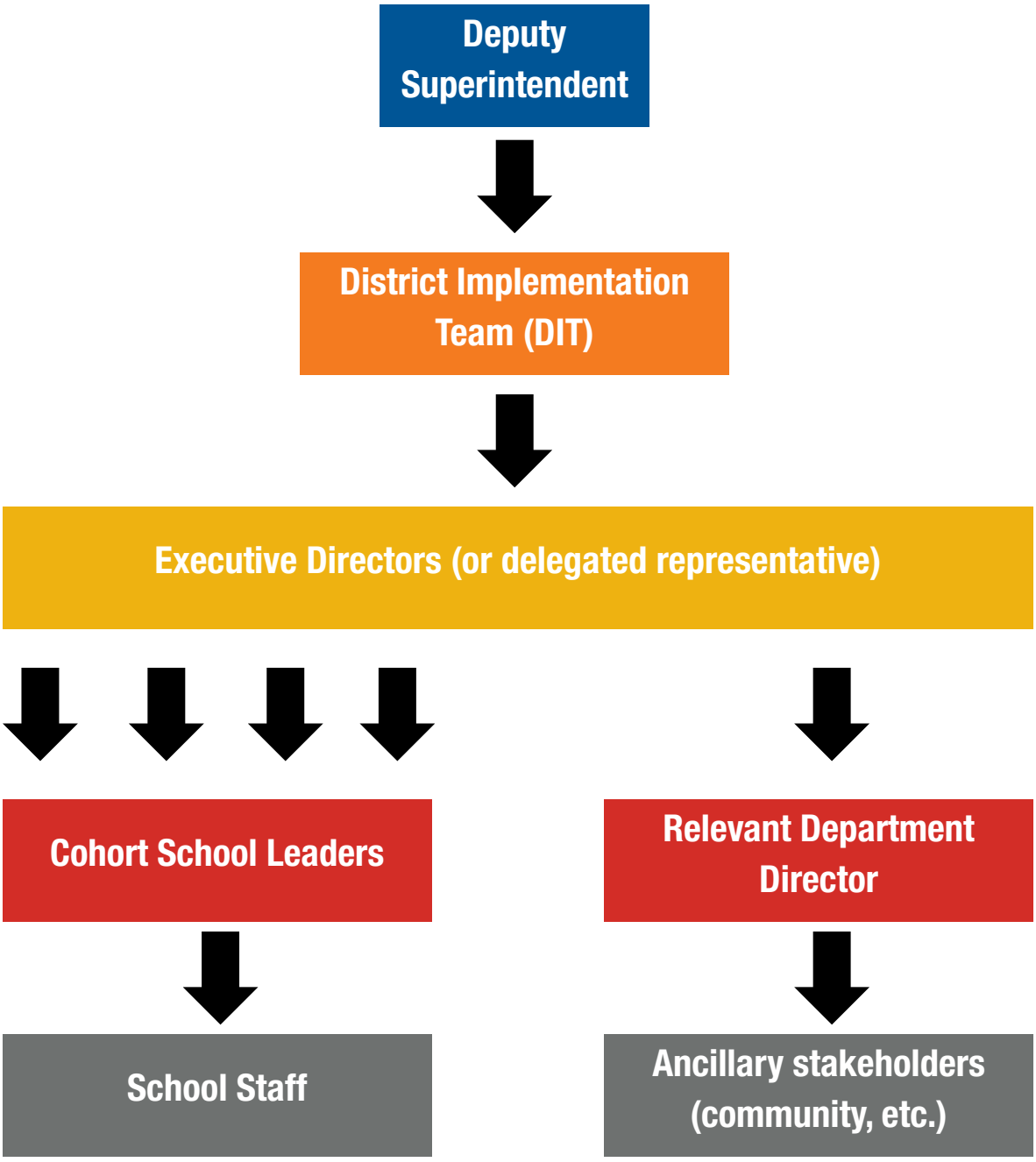
Component	Measurement Metric	Frequency of Reporting
Impact of installation	Suspensions	Monthly
	Minor Behaviors	Monthly
	Attendance (Chronic absenteeism)	Monthly
	Panorama (Sense of Belonging, Positive Feelings, School Climate domains), MI Voice	2x / year (Fall & Spring)
	Effectiveness of interventions	Monthly

Communication Structure

Purpose: To build shared understanding and buy-in across all district and school levels for the implementation of MTSS by aligning communication efforts, ensuring consistent messaging, and reinforcing progress toward implementation goals.

Key Goals:

- Communicate the vision and value of MTSS as a systems-level approach to supporting all students.
- Clarify roles and responsibilities across departments and school leaders.
- Provide regular updates on implementation progress and next steps.
- Celebrate successes and spotlight effective practices.



Communication Roles & Responsibilities

Below are communication roles & responsibilities, by role group:

Role	Responsibilities
Deputy Superintendent	Champion MTSS vision; embed in strategic priorities; communicate key shifts and expectations to all central leadership
Executive Directors	Ensure department alignment; clarify how each area supports MTSS; facilitate cross-department planning
Director of SEL	Communicate the role of Tier 1 behavior supports; lead messaging on climate and culture integration
Director of Community & Student Services	Communicate pathways for supplemental interventions; coordinate training timelines for tier 2 behavior and referral guidance
Designated Tier 3 Representatives	Communicate pathways for intensive supports (including mental health recommendations, or special education referrals) support cohort schools
Director of Curriculum	Ensure Tier 1 instructional practices are aligned with MTSS, lead messaging on Tier 1 instruction, tools & resources

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Communication Plan

Below is a proposed communication plan for MTSS construction, task delegation, and alignment opportunities:

Audience	Lead Communicator	Communication Focus
All District Staff	Superintendent	Vision, alignment to strategic plan, system-wide updates
Executive Directors	Deputy Superintendent	Alignment across departments; role clarity; implementation process
Department Directors (SEL, Community & Student Services, Curriculum, Student Data Services, Professional Learning, Mental Health, FSS, Nursing)	Executive Directors (Quad. ED's, Special Education, CSA)	Department-specific responsibilities and timelines
Principals	Directors (via Executive Directors)	Building-level implementation guidance, expectations
School Tier 1 Teams	Principals, SEL Consultants	Operational plans, data use, fidelity tools
School Tier 2 Teams	Principals, Tier 2 Coordinator	Operational plans, data use, fidelity tools
School Tier 3 Teams	Principals, Designated Tier 3 Representative	Operational plans, data use, fidelity tools
Teachers & Support Staff	Principals & Department Directors	MTSS instructional practices, intervention pathways
Families & Community	Communications Office (in collaboration)	Accessible MTSS purpose, how families are supported

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System Alignment Opportunities

After speaking with many school leaders around the current state of MTSS, these are reported self-constructed barriers that would be beneficial to remove or address prior to continuing an MTSS intiative.



There is an opportunity to develop and communicate a clear, shared vision for MTSS. Stakeholders are not familiar with a GRPS MTSS framework, an installation scope and sequence, a framework for district departments, connections to the Strategic Plan, useful or impactful reports or Synergy dashboards, or menus of possible interventions.



Strengthening communication around MTSS can foster shared understanding and engagement. Cohort 1 schools have only received information about professional learning, but have not received additional communication, resources or planning information about the installation process, nor have non-cohort schools been notified about the MTSS installation process, systems, or structures.



Current data systems are evolving and can be better aligned to support MTSS implementation. There is no single location for scholar data to be accessed, visualized, and utilized commonly. Examples include: Use or non-use of Synergy minor behavior tab, test data located in outside locations (such as ourschooldata), Panorama & MI Voice data hosted on different platforms, secondary grade data requiring constant synchronization. In addition, most schools are not aware of impactful data reports, dashboards or features within Synergy.



There is an opportunity to collaboratively explore impact data to inform continuous improvement. There has not been a conversation about the intended impacts of an effectively installed MTSS with stakeholders. Significant disproportionality of suspensions remains a district priority, but other datapoints will be impacted as well.



Continuous Improvement stays with the District Implementation Team. Receiving feedback from schools participating in the Cohort 1 Professional Learning is an important step, however there has not been communication back to the stakeholder schools highlighting changes that occurred as a result of their feedback.

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Proposed Action Steps

Below are proposed steps to address the system opportunities that have been identified:

Develop an MTSS vision, framework, goals, and implementation plan

Creating and communicating a vision for MTSS will clarify the goals of the MTSS being built, establish common language, clarify expectations, and guide consistent practices across all tiers. This strategic alignment ensures that all stakeholders are working toward the same outcomes, with a roadmap for how to get there. In addition, articulating a scope and sequence for school-level installation and district-wide installation will create context for professional learning sessions and serve as a Key Progress Indicator.

Prioritize shaping district systems and structures around MTSS

Ensuring that systems - such as the Synergy SIS - are aligned with MTSS needs is a critical step in ensuring readiness for MTSS installation. In addition, providing clarity and guidance around the work and procedures of Instructional Leadership Teams, PBIS teams, WHEEL teams, and to a lesser extent Student Success Teams, will create common practices system-wide.

Craft a communication plan, and align tiers of support to relevant district-level departments

Crafting a communication plan and aligning tiers of support with relevant district-level departments will promote coherence, maximize existing resources, and ensure that supports are integrated rather than isolated. In addition, with the relevant departments attending and supporting school's professional learning, there is an assurance of cohesion within the MTSS.

Identify a selection criteria for schools, and determine if schools are given space to opt-out of professional learning for elements that are already at fidelity

Grounding in the Tiered Fidelity Inventory will create a common tool to gauge the levels of implementation of MTSS, and provide schools with objectives that guide installation. In addition, adopting the Tiered Fidelity Inventory can lessen the scope of installation if schools are able to demonstrate the use of best practices and opt-out of MTSS professional learning if tiers of support are already in place.

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